

The Karakum Desert

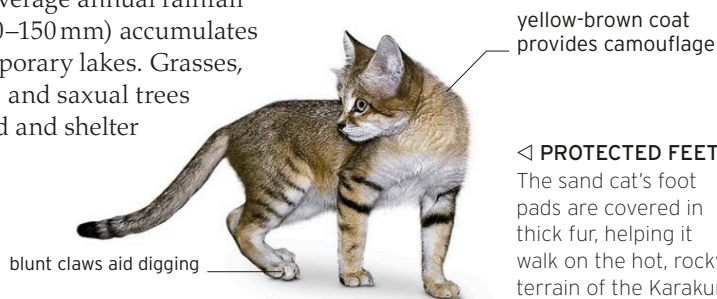
East of the Caspian Sea and south of the Aral Sea, a sparsely vegetated desert of three terrains—and a crater that has burned for decades



The Central Asian Karakum Desert covers about 135,000 square miles (350,000 square km), occupying around 70 percent of Turkmenistan.

Three deserts in one

Southern salt marshes give way to a mineral-rich central plain, then to barren, higher northern areas, constantly eroded by winds. The center contains sand ridges that are 245–295 ft (75–90 m) high, as well as barchans (crescent-shaped dunes) and clay-lined depressions where the average annual rainfall of 3–6 in (70–150 mm) accumulates to form temporary lakes. Grasses, wormwood, and saxaul trees provide food and shelter for wildlife.



▷ DOOR TO HELL

In 1971, a crater created by a Soviet drilling accident released toxic methane gas near Darvaza village. The fire that was lit to burn off the gas has never gone out.



◁ PROTECTED FEET

The sand cat's foot pads are covered in thick fur, helping it walk on the hot, rocky terrain of the Karakum.

The Taklamakan Desert

China's largest desert, composed of fields of shifting dunes that are sporadically convulsed by tornado-like sandstorms



The second-largest shifting sand desert on Earth, surpassed only by the Sahara, the Taklamakan is known as the Sea of Death by the Chinese. Until the 1950s, when the huge Tarim Basin oilfield was discovered beneath it, few people braved the desert's extremely hostile conditions.

Black hurricanes

Constantly shifting dunes (see panel, right) make the 123,550 square miles (320,000 square km) of the Taklamakan difficult to navigate, despite a series of isolated oases scattered at the base of the Tian Shan foothills on its northern border. Mobility aside, the dunes themselves are formidable: some dune chains

are up to 1,640 ft (500 m) wide and 490 ft (150 m) high, and the distance between the chains varies from ½ to 3 miles (1 to 5 km). Fierce winds also cause *karaburans*, or "black hurricanes": sudden violent storms of sand and gravel so dense that they block out sunlight, resulting in dust clouds that rise as high as 13,000 ft (4,000 m).

Although several rivers feed into the desert, bringing snowmelt from the mountains that surround it on three sides, actual precipitation is minimal—only ½–1½ in (10–38 mm) a year. What groundwater there is lies just 10–16 ft (3–5 m) below the surface, and even that is increasingly being compromised by the transportation of oil and gas out of the Tarim Basin via a highway constructed in 1995.

Although classed as a **cold desert**, Taklamakan **summer temperatures** can soar to **100°F (38°C)**

